

Verified

# UEFA Nations League

UEFA introduced the Nations League to replace many international friendlies with competitive league matches. The highest-ranked teams compete for a place in the Nations League Finals.

## UEFA Nations League Finals, 2018-19 onward

| Season                  | Finals host | Winner                   | Runner-up | Third  | Fourth  | Final                                        | Final date  | Story                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------|-------------|--------------------------|-----------|--------|---------|----------------------------------------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">2024-25</a> | Germany     | <a href="#">Portugal</a> | Spain     | France | Germany | 2-2;<br>Portugal 5-3<br><a href="#">pens</a> | 8 June 2025 | <a href="#">▶ Tap to read the story</a><br><br>Portugal beat Spain on penalties in the 2025 final to become the competition's first two-time champion. |

| Season                         | Finals host | Winner                          | Runner-up   | Third   | Fourth      | Final                    | Final date      | Story                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------|-------------|---------|-------------|--------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#"><u>2022-23</u></a> | Netherlands | <a href="#"><u>Spain</u></a>    | Croatia     | Italy   | Netherlands | 0-0; Spain 5-4 pens      | 18 June 2023    | <p>►  <a href="#">Tap to read the story</a></p> <p>Spain won the 2023 final on penalties after a goalless draw with Croatia.</p>                                               |
| <a href="#"><u>2020-21</u></a> | Italy       | <a href="#"><u>France</u></a>   | Spain       | Italy   | Belgium     | France 2-1 Spain         | 10 October 2021 | <p>►  <a href="#">Tap to read the story</a></p> <p>Italy hosted the 2021 Finals without reaching the final itself, finishing third as France beat Spain 2-1 for the title.</p> |
| <a href="#"><u>2018-19</u></a> | Portugal    | <a href="#"><u>Portugal</u></a> | Netherlands | England | Switzerland | Portugal 1-0 Netherlands | 9 June 2019     | <p>►  <a href="#">Tap to read the story</a></p> <p>Portugal won the first-ever Nations League Finals in 2019, beating Netherlands 1-0 as hosts.</p>                          |

## Podium by edition

|                                                                                                           |                                                                                                     |                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>2024-25</b><br>Hosted by Germany<br>🏆 <b>Portugal</b><br>🥈 Spain<br>🥉 France<br>4. Germany             | <b>2022-23</b><br>Hosted by Netherlands<br>🏆 <b>Spain</b><br>🥈 Croatia<br>🥉 Italy<br>4. Netherlands | <b>2020-21</b><br>Hosted by Italy<br>🏆 <b>France</b><br>🥈 Spain<br>🥉 Italy<br>4. Belgium |
| <b>2018-19</b><br>Hosted by Portugal<br>🏆 <b>Portugal</b><br>🥈 Netherlands<br>🥉 England<br>4. Switzerland |                                                                                                     |                                                                                          |

## 🏆 Champions by titles

Generated automatically from the edition table above. Totals group a nation with its sporting predecessor only where the source content does (Germany includes West Germany); every other name is counted as written.

|                              |          |
|------------------------------|----------|
| <b>Portugal</b>              | <b>2</b> |
| <div></div> 2018-19, 2024-25 |          |
| <b>France</b>                | <b>1</b> |
| <div></div> 2020-21          |          |

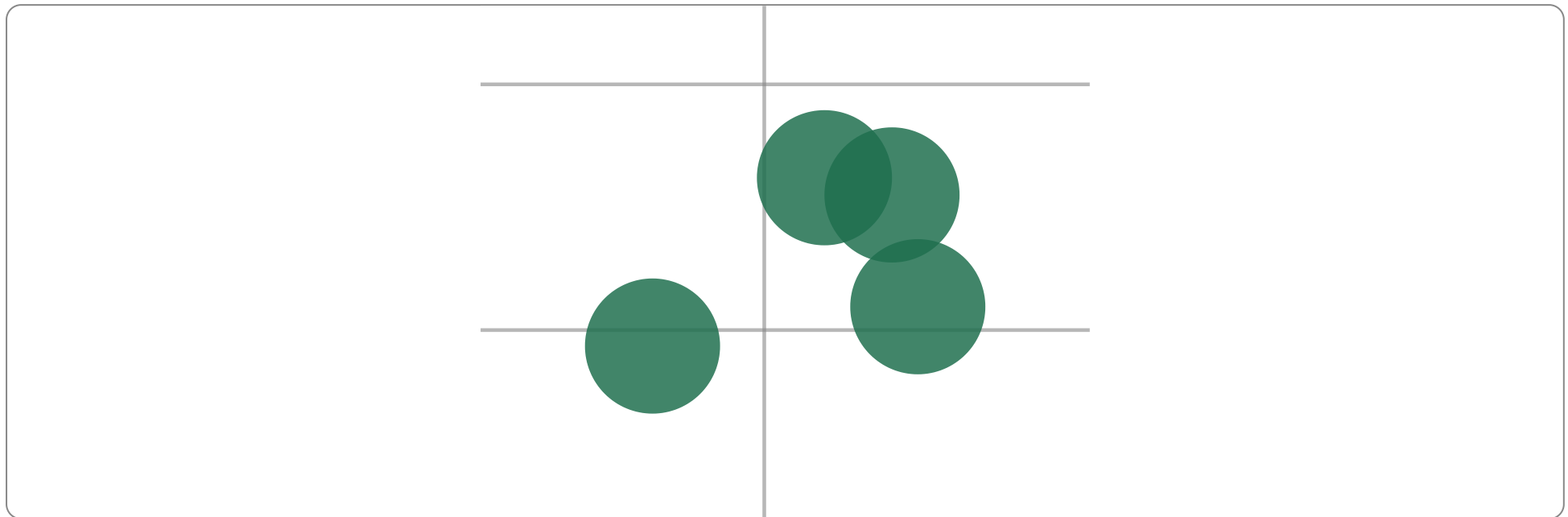
## Spain

1

2022-23

### Where the tournament has been hosted

Every host country's approximate location on a simple latitude/longitude grid, grouped by region in the list below - not a claim of exact borders, just roughly where in the world each edition took place. Bigger dots hosted more than once.



## Europe

**Portugal** 1 time

2018-19

**Italy** 1 time

2020-21

**Netherlands** 1 time

2022-23

**Germany** 1 time

2024-25

## **How it works**

- Every UEFA national team is placed into one of four leagues (A to D) by strength, then split into small groups within its league.
- Teams play each other in their group; results promote the best teams to a higher league and relegate the weakest to a lower one, alongside separate World Cup/EURO qualifying.
- The four League A group winners advance to the Nations League Finals: two semifinals, a third-place match, and a final, all hosted by one of the four finalists.
- Held every two years.

## **Key facts**

- Portugal won the inaugural edition.
- Portugal became the first two-time champion in 2025.
- Croatia reached its first Nations League final in 2023.
- The competition uses promotion and relegation between leagues.

## **Player of the Finals winners**

- UEFA has named a best-player award at every Nations League Finals since the competition's 2019 launch, initially called "Player of the Tournament" before being renamed "Player of the Finals" from 2021 onward.
- **2019:** Bernardo Silva (Portugal).
- **2021:** Sergio Busquets (Spain).
- **2023:** Rodri (Spain).
- **2025:** Nuno Mendes (Portugal).

## **Winning managers**

- **2019:** Fernando Santos (Portugal).

- **2021:** Didier Deschamps (France).
- **2023:** Luis de la Fuente (Spain) - the same season he took charge of Spain, before also winning EURO 2024 and the 2026 World Cup with them.
- **2025:** Roberto Martínez (Portugal) - his first trophy since taking over from Fernando Santos.



## Winning captains

- The captain is the player who lifts the trophy on the podium; every Nations League Finals winner has had one across all four completed editions.
- **2019:** Cristiano Ronaldo (Portugal).
- **2021:** Hugo Lloris (France).
- **2023:** Jordi Alba (Spain) - given the captaincy for the Finals by manager Luis de la Fuente.
- **2025:** Cristiano Ronaldo (Portugal) - the first captain to lift the Nations League trophy twice.



## Memorable moments

- Portugal won the first-ever Nations League Finals in 2019, beating Netherlands 1–0 as hosts.
- Italy hosted the 2021 Finals without reaching the final itself, finishing third as France beat Spain 2–1 for the title.
- Spain won the 2023 final on penalties after a goalless draw with Croatia.
- Portugal beat Spain on penalties in the 2025 final to become the competition's first two-time champion.
- The host nation has finished in the Finals' top four in every edition so far, including Germany finishing fourth in 2025.



## References & review

Status: verified

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Primary sources are preferred. Historical formats and team names are recorded as used at the time; see each edition's notes for context.